CHAPTER 4

Errors: The Fantasy of Infallibility

As Saint Augustine famously said, ‘To err is human; to persist in error is diabolical.’[1] The fallibility of human beings, and the need to correct human errors, have played key roles in every mythology. According to Christian mythology, the whole of history is an attempt to correct Adam and Eve’s original sin. According to Marxist-Leninist thinking, even the working class is likely to be fooled by its oppressors and misidentify its own interests, which is why it requires the leadership of a wise party vanguard. Bureaucracy, too, is constantly on the lookout for errors, from misplaced documents to inefficient procedures. Complex bureaucratic systems usually contain self-disciplinary bodies, and when a major catastrophe occurs – like a military defeat or a financial meltdown – commissions of inquiry are set up to understand what went wrong and make sure that the mistake is not repeated.

In order to function, self-correcting mechanisms need legitimacy. If humans are prone to error, how can we trust the self-correcting mechanisms to be free from error? To escape this seemingly endless loop, humans have often fantasised about some superhuman mechanism, free from all error, that they can rely upon to identify and correct their own mistakes. Today one might hope that AI could provide such a mechanism, as when in April 2023 Elon Musk announced, ‘I’m going to start something, which I call TruthGPT or a maximum truth-seeking AI that tries to understand the nature of the universe.’[2] We will see in later chapters why this is a dangerous fantasy. In previous eras, such fantasies took a different form – religion.

In our personal lives, religion can fulfil many different functions, like providing solace or explaining the mysteries of life. But historically, the